Retouching portraits

Beauty retouching is about enhancing the makeup and the smoothness of the lighting on the face. Portrait retouching requires a fairly similar approach for getting rid of the blemishes and enhancing the skin texture of the subject. However, overall, I find that portrait retouching requires a more subtle approach, as you don't always want to reduce the lines and wrinkles quite so much when retouching portrait photographs. Not all blemishes should necessarily be removed. Take the case of the model Cindy Crawford. In the early years of her modeling career, a lot of magazines wanted a mole on her face to be retouched out. Later on, as she became more famous, nobody would dream of removing it because the pictures would no longer be recognizable as being Cindy!

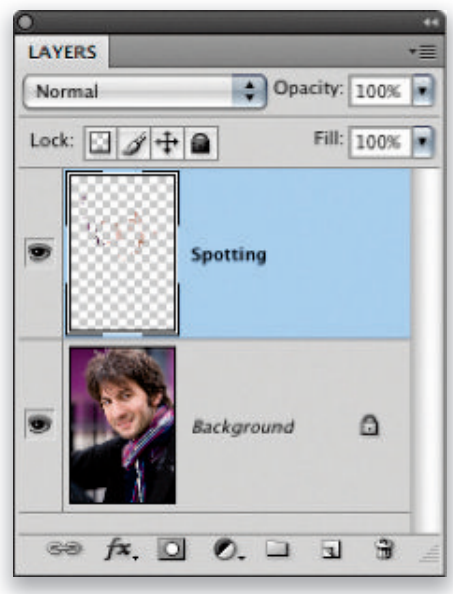
It is interesting how there has been quite a backlash in recent years, with many celebrities reacting against pictures where their faces (as well as their bodies) have been retouched out of all recognition. Our friend Greg Gorman is a well-known celebrity photographer and he tells us that he has made a deliberate effort in recent years to reduce the amount of retouching that is carried out on the portraits he shoots. Having said that, Greg reckons there are many celebrities who quite like seeing themselves retouched and are happy to believe that's how they really look. Plus many of the magazines simply won't publish photographs that feature models or celebrities unless they have had at least a moderate level of retouching done to the images. When Photoshop first came out we saw lots of magazine images where the eyes and teeth were the same white as the paper stock. As a fashion photographer I see lots of examples of badly retouched testing photographs in models' portfolios. My gut feeling is that the magazine editors as well as the general public are becoming tired of the over-retouched look and in recent years we have seen magazines tone down the amount of retouching used, or they are at least now using better retouchers to do the work. Over the next few pages I have shown an example of a classic portrait where the retouching is more restrained, which if anything requires even more skill to get right compared with the beauty retouching example I showed you earlier.



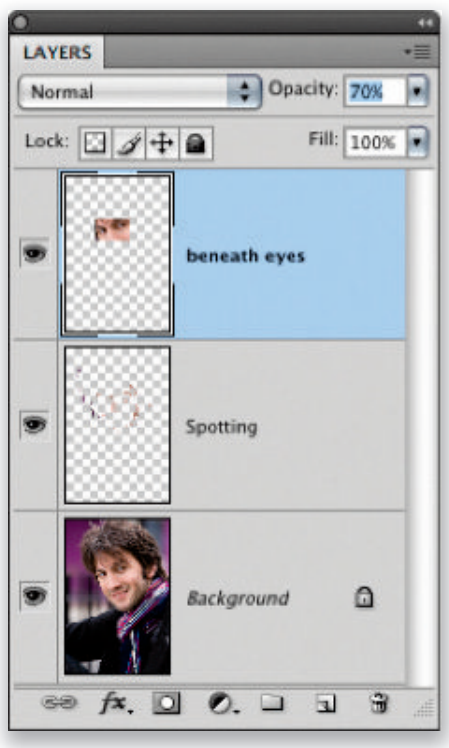
1 This is a portrait of Alex, one of the models used on our Photoshop book shoot, taken by Jeff. Here I wanted to show you the kind of steps that I would typically use to retouch a portrait. These steps are slightly different to the beauty retouching method described earlier because the main objective here was to make the retouching look as completely natural as possible.



2 I began by adding a new empty layer with which to carry out all the initial spotting work using the clone stamp and healing brush tools. If you compare this version with the one above you will notice that I was careful to retouch all the small blemishes and tidy up things like the stray eyebrow hairs and stubble. I didn't remove the mole on Alex's cheek, but I did remove many of the other spots that I felt needed to be retouched.





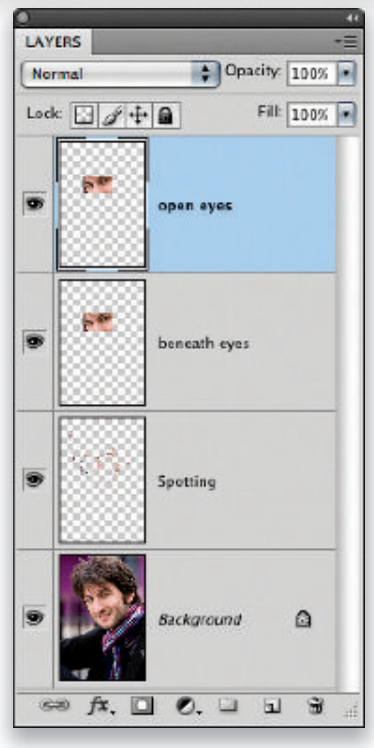


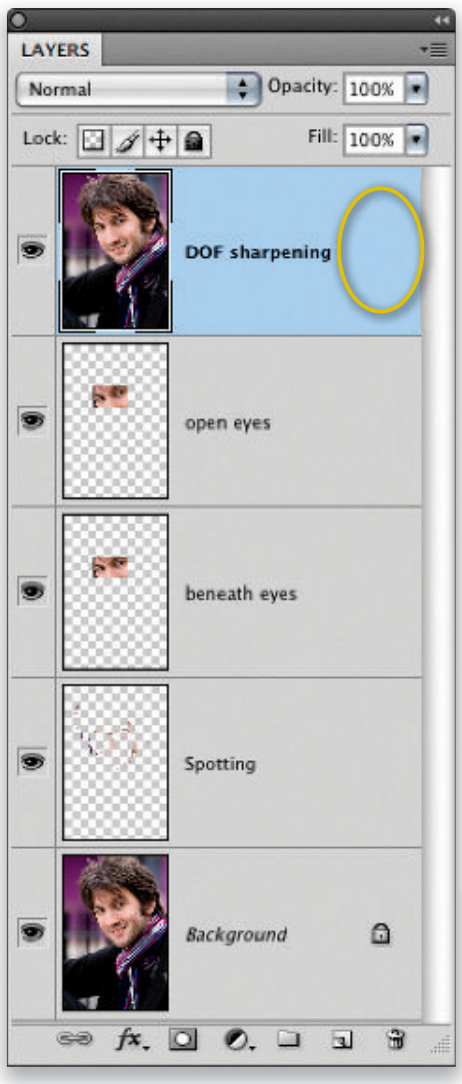


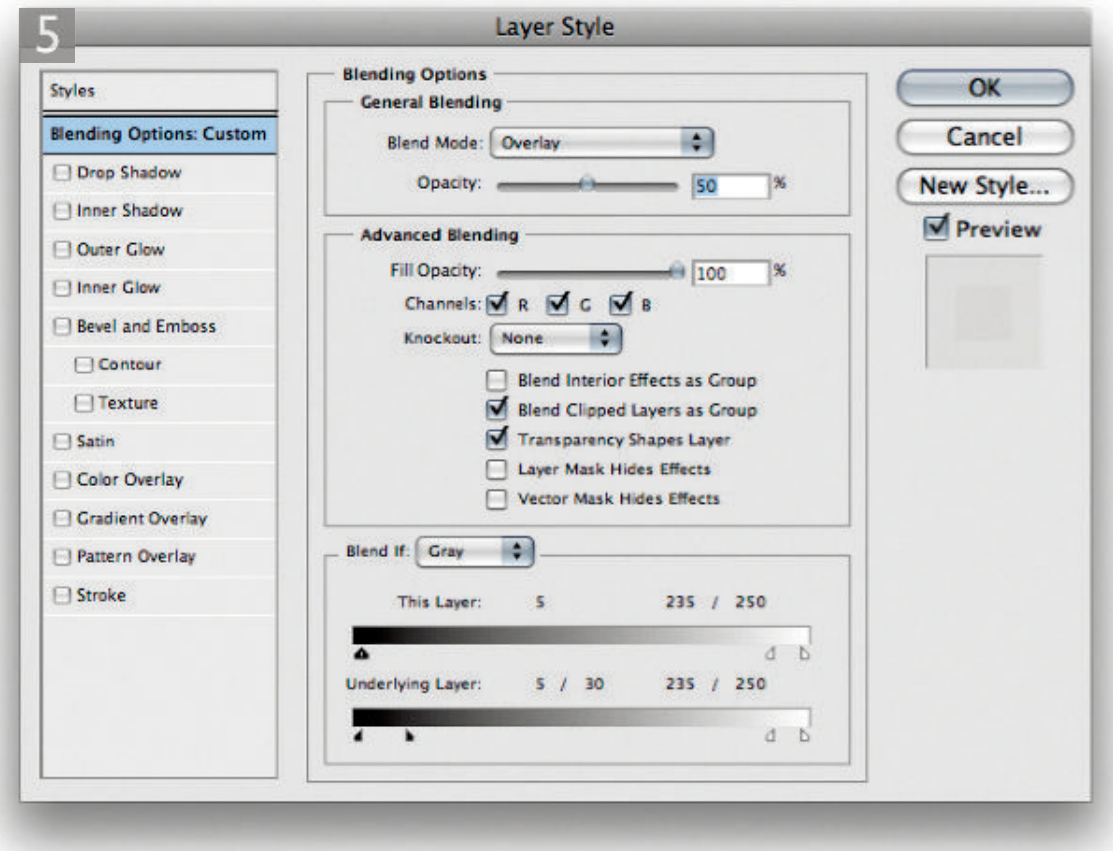
3 Next, I wanted to tackle the bags under the eyes. Even though a fill reflector was used to bounce some light into Alex's face, I felt it would be a good idea to knock these back a little further. To do this, I carried out the Merge copy layer step that was used in the previous retouching example. I used the rectangular marquee tool to select the eyes only and used the ⌘ ⌥ Shift E ctrl alt Shift E shortcut to create a new merged duplicate layer above the Spotting layer, inverted the selection (⌘ Shift I ctrl Shift I) and hit Delete. I now had a merged copy layer of the eyes at the top of the layer stack. I selected the healing brush and used it to carefully remove the crease line. The trick here is to be very careful choosing where you sample from. In this example I had to make sure that the heal cloned texture correctly matched the surrounding skin texture. Once I had completed the healing brush work, I faded the layer opacity to 70% in order to let some of the bags and crease line show through. This avoided letting Alex look like his face had been pumped full of Botox.



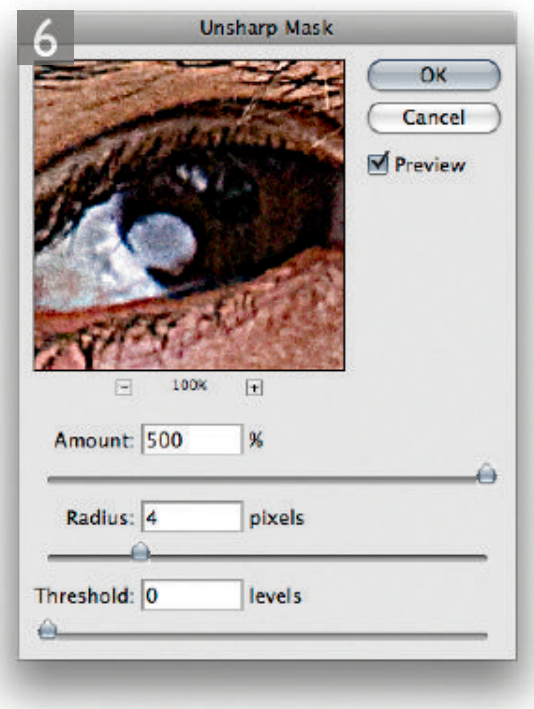
4 I now wanted to open the eyes slightly. If you look closely you can see a reflection of the fill light reflector that was used to bounce more light into Alex's face. The downside of doing this is that his eyes were slightly squinted. To counteract this I repeated the Merge copy layer step, where once again I made a marquee selection of the eyes and used the ⌘ ⌥ Shift E ctrl alt Shift E shortcut to create a new merged duplicate layer above the 'beneath eyes' layer, inverted the selection and hit Delete. I then went to the Filter menu and chose Liquify… In the Liquify dialog shown here I used the warp tool with a low Brush Pressure setting to gently push the lower eyelids open a little more. It was a rather subtle adjustment, but all that was needed to make the eyes look more natural.

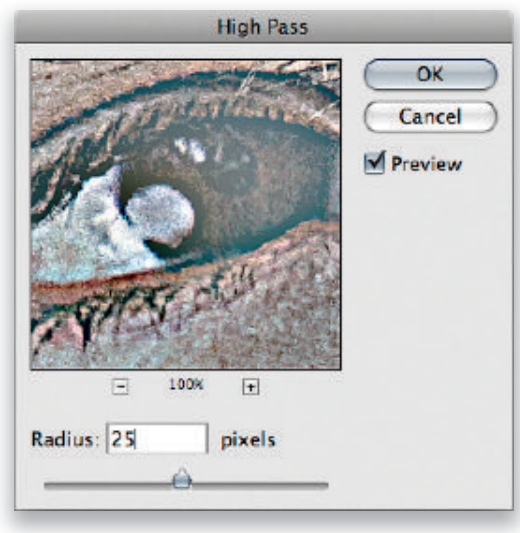






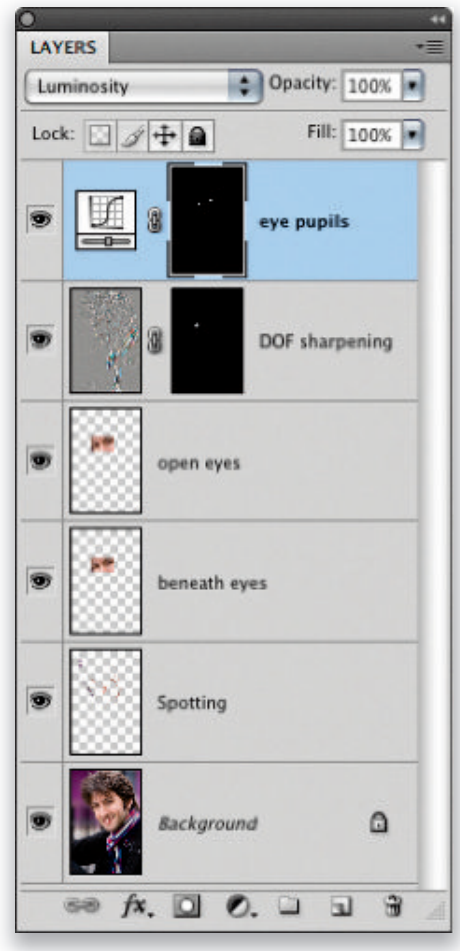
5 I now wanted to make Alex's right eye slightly sharper. To do this I used a technique first devised by Bruce Fraser to create a depth of field sharpening layer. The first step was to create a new merged copy layer using the ⌘ ⌥ Shift E ctrl alt Shift E keyboard shortcut. I then double-clicked on an empty space in the layer (circled), to open the Layer Style dialog shown here, where I set the layer opacity to 50%, the blend mode to Overlay and adjusted the Blend If sliders as shown here.

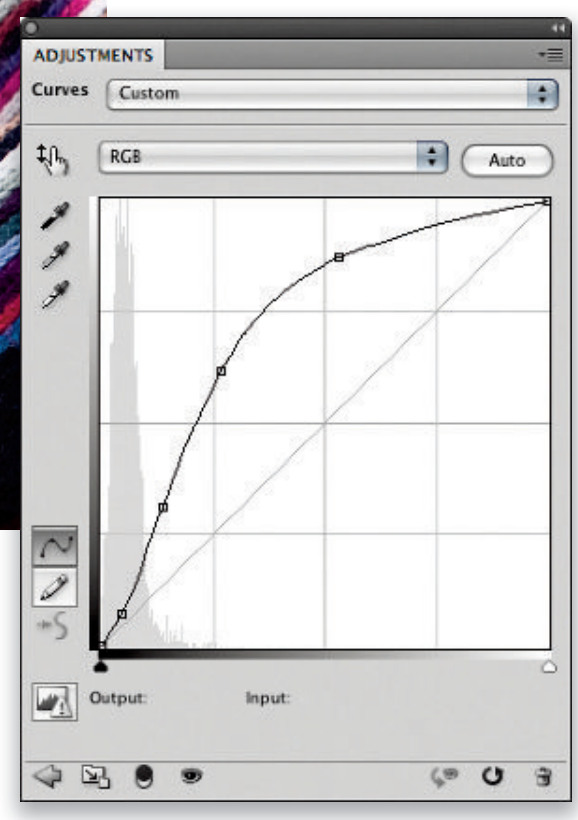




6 I went to the Filter ⇨ Sharpen menu and applied the Unsharp Mask filter to the merged copy layer using the settings shown here, followed by the Filter ⇨ Other ⇨ High Pass filter using a 25 pixels Radius.







7 Here is the completed photograph. You will notice that I added a Curves adjustment layer to lighten the eye pupils. I added the adjustment layer first, filled the layer mask with black to hide the effect and then painted on the mask with white to reveal the adjustment in the pupils only. As I did this I was careful not to make the catch light reflection any lighter. If you compare this version with the original you'll see quite a transformation compared to what we started out with. Yet I still managed to preserve the skin texture and keep the portrait looking fairly natural.